

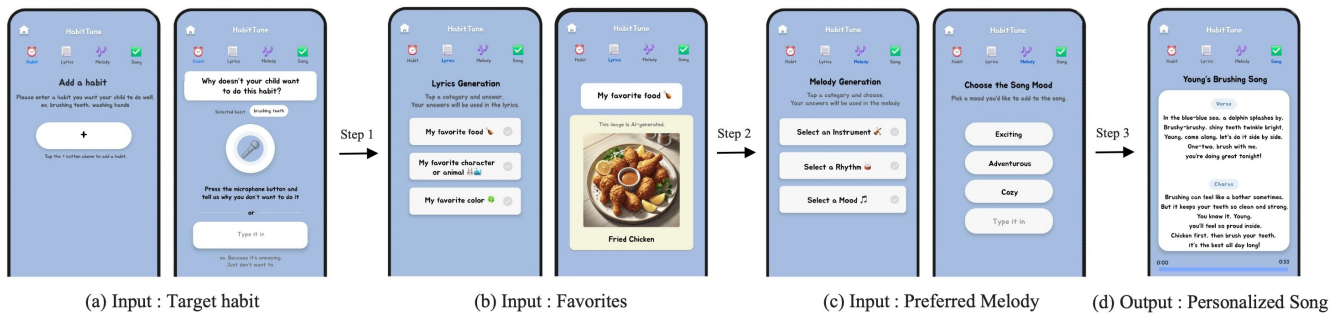
# HabitTune: AI-Generated Personalized Children's Songs for Positive Habit Development

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**Figure 1: The overview of song generation process using HabitTune. It takes a daily target habit and captures the child's reluctance reason from a parent as an input (Step1), generates personalized lyrics and a keyword-aligned image given the child's favorite things (Step2), allows parents and children to select their preferred instrument, rhythm and mood to generate a melody (Step3), and then it generates a personalized habit-support song as a final output.**

## Abstract

Early childhood habits lay the groundwork for lifelong personality and socio-emotional development, yet poor internalization may weaken self-regulation and increase daily resistance. Prior habit-support systems often target specific behaviors and are difficult to personalize across diverse home contexts. Thus, we present HABITUNE, a generative AI-based system that creates personalized children's songs grounded in positive framing. The system combines a target habit with children's preference cues (e.g., foods, colors, characters) to generate supportive songs. We conducted a two-week home study with nine families of children aged 3–6, who listened to their personalized song daily. Parents rated HABITUNE as highly usable ( $SUS = 82.75$ ) and described the songs as engaging and helpful, reporting perceived improvements in habit enactment

and related attitudes. These findings suggest AI-personalized songs may offer a lightweight scaffold for supporting everyday habit routines.

## CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → *User studies; HCI design and evaluation methods.*

## Keywords

Personalization; Children's songs; Habit formation; Positive framing; Generative AI; HCI

## ACM Reference Format:

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## 1 Introduction

Habits established in early childhood—such as hygiene routines, sleep patterns, and eating behaviors—provide a foundation for later

socio-emotional development [20]. When these habits are not internalized, children may rely on repeated reminders and show weaker self-regulated enactment, increasing friction in family routines [10, 25, 30]. Prior HCI systems have supported children's routines via sensors, interactive media, and gamification [8, 15, 17, 23], but many focus on a single, predefined behavior (e.g., eating speed or food intake) or require setups that are difficult to scale across diverse home contexts.

Children's songs can aid attention and memorability through rhythm and repetition and have been used to support daily-life habits [12, 21, 35]. However, one-size-fits-all content may lose engagement, motivating preference-based personalization [31, 39]. While generative-AI personalization has progressed in story-making and reading [7, 13, 42], comparatively little work has examined AI-generated personalized children's songs embedded in family routines to support habit enactment.

To address this gap we introduce HABITUNE, which generates a habit-support song by combining the target habit, the child's reason for disliking it, and preference cues. HABITUNE uses positive framing to emphasize immediate, concrete benefits [22] and adopts an autonomy-supportive perspective [41] to encourage collaboration and internalization rather than compliance [29].

We conducted a 14-day guided intervention with 9 parents of preschool-aged children (3–6 years). Parents played the personalized song at least twice daily and submitted daily reports. Families often used songs immediately before or during the routine as cues and, at times, as a substitute for repeated prompting; reports and interviews suggested improved enactment quality/independence, reduced resistance, and emerging internalization.

Overall this work demonstrates the feasibility of using generative AI to create preference-based personalized children's songs and integrate them into family routines. By treating songs as an interactional mediator that can reduce repeated prompting and support routine entry, our findings suggest a practical direction for more positive and collaborative habit support in the home.

## 2 System: HabitTune

As shown in Figure 1, HabitTune generates personalized songs with generative AI, using positive framing grounded in the child's target habit and preference cues (e.g., favorite food, color, animal/character) to support habit enactment. Building on prior work for AI-based children's song creation [3], we refine the lyric-generation principles and replace Suno AI [36] with Minimax Music [6] for music generation to improve the quality and naturalness of Korean-language songs, add explicit melody controls, and incorporate the child's name and reason for disliking the target habit as personalization cues.

**2.1 Target-Habit Setup.** A parent selects one daily target habit and provides the child's reluctance reason either via voice (transcribed with STT) or direct text input. This reason is stored as an explicit conditioning variable for lyric generation.

**2.2 Lyric Generation.** The system collects preference cues (e.g., favorite food, color, character/animal) via voice or text and uses them to construct a lyric-generation prompt for ChatGPT-4o-mini [27]. The prompt produces a structured verse-chorus format that

includes (i) an empathy line acknowledging reluctance and (ii) gain-framed supportive dialogue and modeling by a preferred character/animal [1, 32]. In parallel, HABITUNE generates a keyword-aligned image using DALL-E through category-specific prompts with safety filters, and restricts outputs using structured JSON formats and clear content rules to reduce unsafe or ambiguous content [14].

**2.3 Melody and Song Generation.** Parents and children select the instrument, rhythm, and mood of the song through the interface. Instruments (e.g., piano or guitar), rhythm styles (e.g., bouncy, lively, or slow), and mood descriptors (e.g., calm or playful) can be chosen from preset options or specified via additional user input. Each selection is converted into control tokens, which are combined with the finalized lyrics and passed to Minimax Music [6] as a structured prompt to synthesize a melody appropriate for a children's song.

## 3 Method

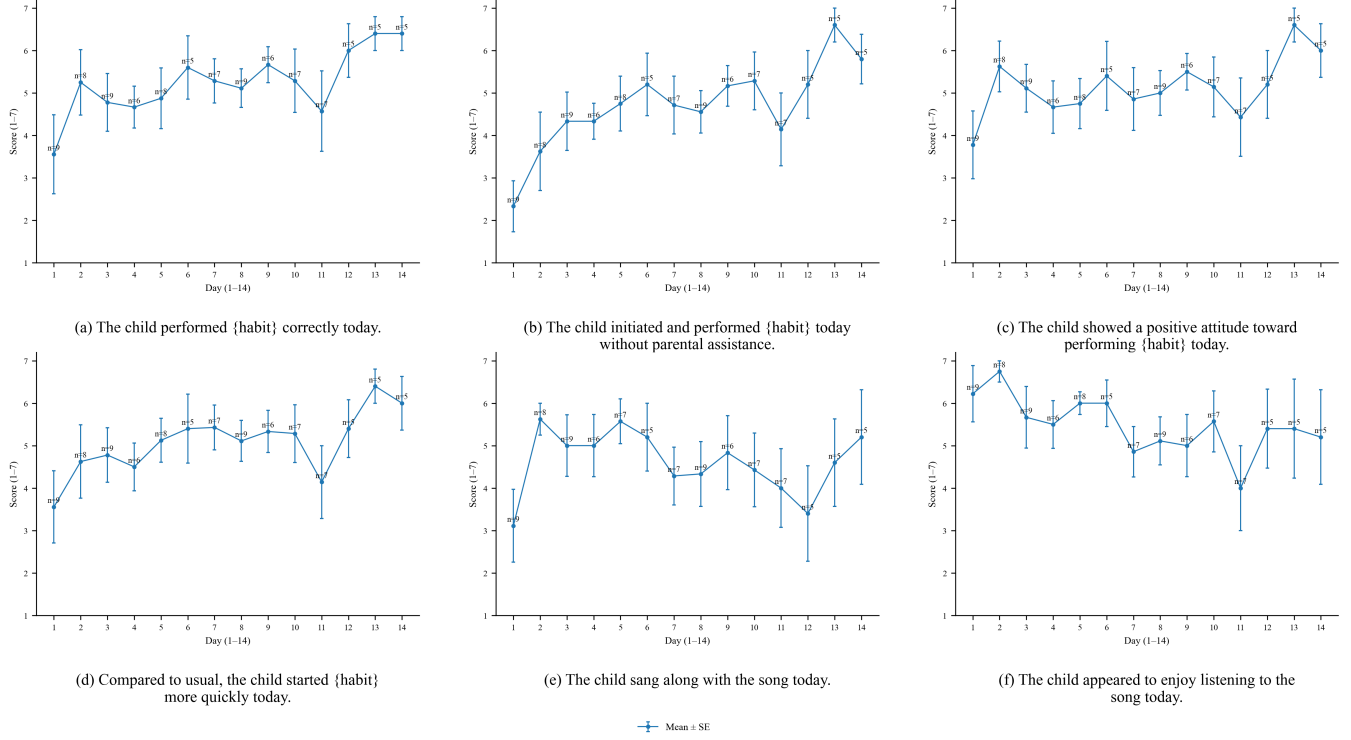
**3.1 Participants.** We recruited parents of preschool-aged children (aged 3–6) who could use the Android-based HABITUNE app via online parenting communities and school bulletin boards. We focused on preschool age to target early childhood, when habit routines are still consolidating and song-based scaffolds are likely to fit children's developmental level and everyday home practices [4, 26, 33]. Ten children participated (6 girls, 4 boys; 45–77 months;  $M=63.8$  months). All participation was voluntary and compensated.

**3.2 Apparatus.** We deployed the Android-based HABITUNE app for home use. The app logged (i) song-creation inputs (e.g., preference cues) and generated lyrics, and (ii) playback events (timestamps and song information). Questionnaires were administered via Google Forms, and post-intervention interviews were conducted by phone and audio-recorded with consent.

**3.3 Procedure.** Parents first received a study explanation and provided informed consent, then completed a pre-intervention questionnaire and joined a remote onboarding session via Google Meet. During onboarding, we provided oral instructions and a brief tutorial for app installation and use. Parents then spent ~10 minutes co-creating a personalized song with their child using HABITUNE, after which they completed the System Usability Scale (SUS) [16]. During the 14-day guided intervention, parents were instructed to play the song created on the first day at least twice daily at self-chosen times and submit a daily parent report, with KakaoTalk reminders sent each evening at 8:00 PM. After the intervention, parents completed a post-intervention questionnaire and participated in an audio-recorded phone interview.

**3.4 Data and Analysis.** To reduce recall bias and capture day-to-day change [5, 37], we collected daily parent reports during the 14-day intervention (six closed-ended items and two open-ended questions). Analyses included submitted days only; for closed-ended items, we (i) aggregated responses by day to examine trajectories and (ii) computed respondent-level means and standard deviations.

We also administered a 7-point Likert questionnaire assessing children's habit enactment and related attitudes [9, 24, 33, 40], with parents rating 13 metrics at pre- and post-intervention. App logs



**Figure 2: Day-by-day patterns of daily-report items over the 14-day intervention (1–7 Likert scale). Blue shows mean  $\pm$  SE and orange shows the median; annotated values indicate the number of responses per day ( $n$ ).**

(song metadata and playback records) were analyzed to contextualize parent reports. Post-intervention interviews were coded by two researchers (Cohen's  $\kappa = 0.84$ ). Data from one family who withdrew (P2) were excluded.

## 4 Results

Overall, parents rated HABITUNE as highly usable (SUS:  $M=82.75$ ,  $SD=11.27$ ) and showed strong willingness to continue playing personalized songs to support their child's habit improvement ( $M=6.33$  out of 7,  $SD=1.12$ ). Here we summarize key findings.

### 4.1 The Analysis of Input Used for Song Generation

Tidying up was most frequently selected as the target habit ( $N=3$ ), followed by brushing teeth ( $N=2$ ), while other routines were selected once each. Rabbit was the most common animal/character, and carrots were the most frequently entered food. Upbeat and bouncy rhythms with exciting or cozy moods predominated.

The predominance of upbeat moods aligns with prior work suggesting that playful approaches can positively influence children's motivation in habit contexts [28]. Incorporating children's preferred elements may help present habits in more personally meaningful ways [41].

### 4.2 How Songs Were Used at Home

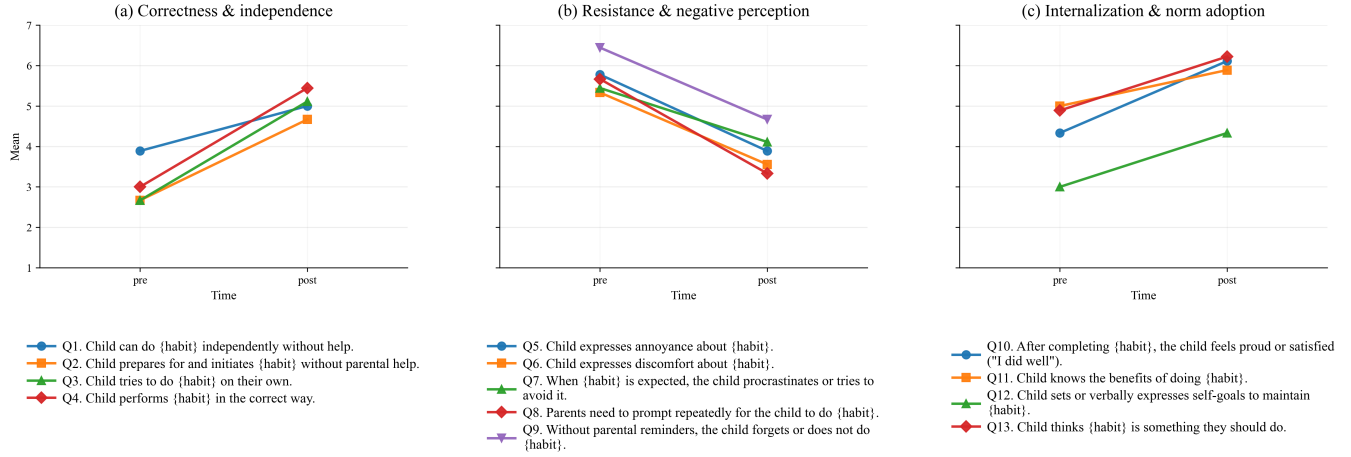
Playback logs showed that families played the song 6.65 times/day on days it was used ( $SD=3.21$ ); averaged across the full 14-day period, the mean was 4.58 plays/day ( $SD=3.38$ ). The song was most often played immediately before the target habit ( $N=6$ ), consistent with interview reports that parents used it as a cue to prompt habit initiation ( $N=5$ ). The song was also frequently played during enactment ( $N=6$ ).

In describing children's responses, parents most often mentioned singing along ( $N=8$ ) and enjoyment ( $N=4$ ), and some noted attention to personalization cues (e.g., hearing their name;  $N=3$ ).

Fig. 2(e,f) shows a typical novelty fade in children's responses with repeated use. To support sustained engagement, future designs could incorporate (i) adding musical variation across listens (e.g., alternative versions or small changes in melody and arrangement) and (ii) encouraging movement-coupled listening, such as simple gestures or dance-like actions [18]. Playback during enactment further points to opportunities for duration-aligned personalized songs that better match routine length (e.g.,  $\sim 20$  s for handwashing;  $\sim 3$  min for toothbrushing) [34], providing continuous accompaniment and emotional support throughout the routine.

### 4.3 Songs Reframing Habit Enactment as Playful Activity

Fig. 2(a,b) and Fig. 3(a) show upward trends in target habit correctness and independence. In post-intervention interviews, seven



**Figure 3: Mean parent-reported habit questionnaire scores at Pre-intervention (baseline) and Post-intervention (after the 2-week guided song-listening period), grouped into three themes (a-c). Item-level statistics are provided in the Appendix table.**

parents reported that their child enacted the habit more accurately than before, whereas two reported no clear change. These limited effects were attributed to concerns about age-appropriateness (the song felt childish for a 6-year-old; P6) and declining interest over time (P9).

Across habits, parents described more thorough, rhythm-aligned handwashing (P1), fewer passive toothbrushing behaviors and more appropriate brushing motions (P6), and more self-initiated tidying routines (P3). P4 noted that the child still expressed reluctance, yet more often initiated enactment by asking to do it together. P3 and P7’s accounts suggest that the song helped reframe the habit as “play” or a “mission”.

These changes may reflect a reduction in negative affect or perceived burden that previously served as an entry barrier between knowing what should be done and actually doing it [11]. Parents explained that playing the song helped shift the habit from a burdensome task to a more approachable activity—often framed as play or a mission. Taken together, personalized songs may be associated with reframing routines in a more playful, game-like way, as reflected in parents’ descriptions [2].

#### 4.4 Easing Resistance Through Emotional Shifts and Cueing

Fig. 3(b) shows a downward pattern in resistance and negative perceptions from pre- to post-intervention. In line with this, Fig. 2(c,d) suggests increasingly positive attitudes and shorter latency to initiate the habit over time. Interviews converged: many parents reported less everyday tension ( $N=7$ ), and some described using the songs to shift mood and ease resistance ( $N=4$ ).

A few parents noted that songs partially substituted for repeated verbal prompting (“nagging”) ( $N=2$ ), making reminders feel more like a cue and reducing conflict. For instance, P3 reported fewer excuses and smoother transitions into tidying, and P5 described a previously resisted routine becoming more attempted—and sometimes independently enacted—at daycare.

One possible interpretation is that gain-framed, self-efficacy-supportive lyrics may have shaped how the habit was appraised; however, alternative explanations (e.g., musical novelty, parental mediation, or developmental change) remain plausible [22]. The song may also have served as a mood-shifter that helps regulate negative affect. However, mechanisms cannot be isolated, as changes may reflect the musical medium, personalization, parental prompting shifts, or development. Future work should incorporate children’s perspectives via developmentally appropriate, low-burden methods to better link song experiences to attitudinal change.

#### 4.5 Emerging Internalization Beyond the Song

As shown in Fig. 3(c), internalization and norm adoption tended to increase from pre- to post-intervention. Interviews suggested that some children began to appraise the target habit’s value and take greater ownership (e.g., P9: “Is tidying up important?”), alongside contextual generalization such as tidying extending beyond the playroom (e.g., P3).

Parents also reported cases where children enacted the habit without playing the song (yes  $N=6$ , no  $N=3$ ), including stating the rule to others (P1), performing it in other settings (P3), and self-directed reminders (P7). Together, these reflections align with early meaning-making and self-regulation processes [38]. Consistent with Kochanska’s notion of internalized conduct—rule-consistent behavior without supervision or external incentives—these patterns may signal an early shift from externally prompted compliance toward self-relevant norm adoption [19]. However, given the two-week window, we cannot assess whether changes extend to automaticity; longer follow-up (e.g.,  $\geq 3$  months) is needed to examine durability and generalization.

### 5 Conclusion

We present HABITUNE, an AI system that generates personalized children’s songs with positively framed lyrics grounded in a target habit and a child’s preference cues (e.g., favorite food, color, and animal/character). In a two-week home deployment with

daily listening, we observed patterns consistent with habit-related change, including improved enactment quality, more positive attitudes, reduced resistance, and early indications of internalization (e.g., occasional self-initiated enactment without the song). Parents described the songs as both a practical cue that helped children initiate the habit and an autonomy-supportive tool for regulating negative emotions, suggesting a plausible pathway through which everyday resistance may be reduced.

This work explains how AI-personalized songs are used at home and what kinds of changes in habits may be associated with their use. It also outlines a concrete design space for generative-AI behavior-change systems for families, pointing to opportunities for richer musical variation and for comparative evaluations that disentangle the roles of personalization and music.

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